

MY FIRST TWO YEARS

People sometimes ask what I do all day, as in, “So how do you keep from going crazy?” So I tell them. Maybe it’s time I told you too.

I grew up in a Los Angeles suburb where most of the other kids came from richer families than I did. I paid attention to what money could and could not do. Money couldn’t buy good grades, I noticed, or a home run in the bottom of the ninth. Money couldn’t keep your best friend from breaking his neck in a freak diving accident. Money couldn’t keep people from complaining or yelling at you.

But money *could* rent a beach house. More than ice cream, Dodgers’ games, or a shiny bicycle, when I was small I decided life’s best thing would be a beach house. I figured our family came pretty close. Every August we took our house trailer to the state campgrounds at San Clemente or Doheny Beach. Besides my mother, father, grandfather, sister, and three brothers, my aunts, uncles, and cousins poured into the campground as well. The men commuted to work while the rest of us ran up and down the beach, rode the waves, fished, or played ball. At night we’d sit around a small fire and sing. The last Saturday night of the season we’d cook T-bones on an outdoor grill. Man, that was living.

As I grew up I started to dream a little. What would be better than a house trailer? A beach house. What would be better than August at the beach with those you loved the most? A whole summer at the beach with those you loved the most. What would be better than commuting to work? Staying at the beach all week long. What would be better than a steak on Saturday night? A steak anytime you wanted one.

I thought it was a good dream—I still do—and when I retired I decided the first thing to do was live it. When I retired in late 1984, Vicki and I headed for the beach in Pínamar, Argentina. (Remember, summer comes in January, February, and March in the southern hemisphere.) We rented a comfortable two-bedroom apartment a block from the water.